A WATERDEEP & UNDERMOUNTAIN CAMPAIGN

THE ECHO BELOW

A home above. A mystery below.

DUNGEON MASTER'S CAMPAIGN BOOK

ILLUSTRATED CAMPAIGN EDITION

At the table

Run a campaign where Waterdeep becomes home, Undermountain supplies the mystery, and the party decides what the Echo should become.

This book gathers the established campaign, the complete Waterdeep hub, new field adventures, ready-to-use clues, and preparation tools. It contains Dungeon Master secrets.

Rules reference: Use your chosen Dungeons & Dragons rules and owned adventures for full rules, official room keys, creature statistics, and treasure. This is a custom campaign companion. Suggested checks, encounter roles, and original procedures support preparation; the party and chosen edition determine final balance.

Art at the table: Campaign artwork is illustrative. Use the written continuity for the exact number and meaning of the Nine, and reveal secret locations or relationships only when appropriate.

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Current party and checkpoint

Updated 26 September 2026. These are the approved configured level-3 builds, not a reset of the live table's damage, expended resources, equipment, or money. Live phone sheets take precedence for in-session changes.

Trista

Player: Existing player

Class: Monk · Warrior of Shadow

Level: 3

Maximum HP: 21

AC: 14

Pebble

Player: Byron

Class: Fighter · Champion

Level: 3

Maximum HP: 23

AC: 18

Donavan Kemp

Player: Brodey

Class: Wizard 2 / Cleric 1 · Order of Scribes / Knowledge Domain

Level: 3

Maximum HP: 24

AC: 16

Ringgo Paul

Player: Cade

Class: Rogue · Assassin

Level: 3

Maximum HP: 24

AC: 16

Aldric Vane

Player: Bowman

Class: Wizard · School of Evocation

Level: 3

Maximum HP: 25

AC: 12

Trista uses the 2024 Monk with Warrior of Shadow. Pebble uses the 2014 Champion fighter, custom Goron lineage, Crusher, and Interception. Donavan uses Wizard 2 / Cleric 1. Ringgo uses the 2014 Assassin; his Expertise choices are Stealth and Investigation. Aldric uses the 2014 Evocation wizard, Reborn lineage, and the approved normal wizard HP calculation. The 42 HP export value was not adopted.

All listed spells for Donavan and Aldric remain available under the DM-approved house rule. Donavan's Mind Sliver and Catapult remain named exceptions. This does not grant extra slots, actions, or spell levels.

Dracuseth: remains a Waterdeep NPC and is not a sixth party member or automatic traveling ally.

Current position

Sessions 2-3 are a combined actual-play record. The party learned of the Black Spider and that the Redbrands have Gundren, cleared the orc camp, and saw Hamun Kost disappear without a fight. Play stopped just before entering the Redbrand hideout. The exact entrance and the individual session split were not supplied.

Use the actual play record and the app's Campaign continuity view for approved facts. Prepared encounters, future Nine-site material, and possible endings are plans until they occur.

Current handouts

Use the current handout index. Explicitly named Session 1 and Level 2 handouts are historical snapshots. They do not supersede current sheets. Private character information belongs only with that character and the DM.

Sessions 2-3: actual play

DM-approved record, updated 26 September 2026. The events are recorded together because the DM did not assign them to individual sessions. Their order below is a summary, not a reconstructed chronology.

Confirmed outcomes

- The party learned that the Black Spider exists. Identity, location, and the full plan have not been reported as discovered.
- The party learned that the Redbrands have Gundren. This records what the party learned, not a confirmed present location.
- The party killed the orc camp. Individual enemy fates, treasure, and payment of a reward were not supplied.
- Hamun Kost, the wizard at Old Owl Well (called “Koth” in the initial report), disappeared instead of fighting. His destination and method of disappearance are unknown.
- Play stopped immediately before the party entered the Redbrand hideout.

Where to resume

Resume outside the Redbrand hideout. Ask the players to describe their entrance and approach before revealing rooms or placing them inside. Use the prepared Redbrand runbook as possible upcoming play. The hideout's encounters, prisoners, treasure, and Glasstaff's fate are unplayed.

Optional opening to read:

> *You have learned of a figure called the Black Spider, and your search for Gundren has led to the Redbrands. The orc camp is behind you. At Old Owl Well, Hamun Kost vanished rather than face you, leaving his whereabouts unanswered. Now you are about to enter the Redbrands' hideout. Before you go in, what is your plan, and who takes the lead?*

This opening gives no entrance, formation, elapsed time, weather, or rest that the DM has not confirmed.

DM-only truth and knowledge boundaries

The DM previously established that Redbrands abducted Gundren and delivered him to Cragmaw Castle. The party's latest reported information is that the Redbrands have him. Do not reveal the castle destination automatically. The apparent difference is a lead to investigate, not permission to put Gundren inside the hideout.

Trista retains the BELOW token privately. Donavan noticed concealment in Session 1, but the token's identity was not shared. Hamun Kost's disappearance is unresolved; it does not prove death, teleportation, an alliance, or that he warned anyone.

No NPC automatically learns everything the party knows. Select actual witnesses or recipients in each continuity event. No further rescue, promise, debt, payment, item transfer, or rest is recorded without confirmation.

Connections in the app

Open **Story > Campaign continuity & quests**. Approved events supply quest status, shared journal entries, map annotations, phone journal entries, NPC knowledge, and obligation/custody records. The Old Owl Well marker can now appear as a known place; Cragmaw Castle and Wave Echo Cave remain unrevealed unless manually revealed or supported by another approved discovery.

The orc objective is complete; reward collection is unconfirmed. Because the camp's name was not explicitly given, the record does not reveal a new regional destination by inference.

Next-session recording checklist

After play, record which entrance was used; encounters resolved and how; people rescued, killed, captured, or escaped; discoveries and who learned them; actual loot and custody; promises or debts; and the exact stopping point. Keep future possibilities labeled planned.

The campaign at a glance

Current checkpoint (26 September 2026): Trista, Pebble, Donavan Kemp, Ringgo Paul, and Aldric Vane are level 3. Dracuseth stays in Waterdeep. Resume before entering the Redbrand hideout. See current party and Sessions 2-3 actual record. Everything described as a future scene remains planned.

Campaign premise

The Echo Below begins as a rescue story near Phandalin and grows into a campaign about what people owe one another when knowledge becomes powerful enough to change a world. The party starts at level 1 in **Lost Mine of Phandelver**, reaches Waterdeep at roughly level 5, and uses the Yawning Portal as home while exploring **Dungeon of the Mad Mage** and the eight distant resonance sites.

The central mystery is the **Echo**: a two-part sensation. First comes a physical event - surf in a cave, a struck rope, a shifting stone. A heartbeat later comes a quiet pressure behind the eyes. That pressure is resonance from the knot in the Weave beneath Waterdeep. It is not a sound, a god, a portal network, or a promise that every mystery has one villain.

The campaign's nine sites

There are exactly nine sites: Undermountain at the center and eight satellites. The black-stone medallion, **Echo's Whisper**, records that relationship: one large center and eight smaller circles. It does not tell the party where to go, open doors, or grant finished powers. A named site can be dormant; studying it never automatically activates it.

What the campaign is about

Waterdeep should feel worth protecting. Give the party meals, jobs, friendships, small celebrations, and people who expect them home. The dungeon and satellite sites should challenge that comfort with four recurring questions:

- **Home:** What makes a place worth returning to?
- **Curiosity:** What evidence is worth pursuing, and what must be protected while it is pursued?
- **Temptation:** What does a valuable or dangerous thing cost its keeper?
- **Responsibility:** Who bears the risk when a discovery affects ordinary people?

Campaign themes

The answer must belong to the players. Do not make the Still Hand automatically correct, Halaster automatically all-knowing, or the knot a confirmed sentient villain. Make claims visible, let evidence complicate them, and make every consequential choice legible before it is irreversible.

The opening: Phandalin to Waterdeep

Run the published opening normally. The Echo is seasoning, not a replacement for goblins, townsfolk, and Gundren's rescue.

Session 1: Goblin Arrows

Goal: Find Gundren and Sildar after the ambush. Keep the encounter and Cragmaw Hideout as the immediate story. Gundren hired Trista because he trusts her after giving her a second chance; he hired Donavan because a careful field researcher can recognize whether a mine discovery is ordinary wealth or something that should be documented before it is sold; and he gave Ringgo a legitimate escort job in which keeping people alive matters more than making someone disappear. None of them begins with secret knowledge of the Echo.

Historical Session 1 starting party: Trista, Donavan, and Ringgo are joined by Pebble and Aldric Vane in Session 1. Aldric is a level-1 Reborn Wizard and former Crown magistrate seeking atonement and his lost family. His DM-built combat sheet is ready; Evocation begins at wizard level 2. Pebble seeks the delicious shiny rocks described by the dwarves who made his hammer and values traveling with others because he fears getting lost. Invite Bowman to describe why Aldric took Gundren's job and give them equal say in the opening choices. Dracuseth remains in Waterdeep and is not on the wagon or in the opening encounters.

After the party's first quiet moment, place a rough black token among the goblins' castoffs. One side says **BELOW**. The reverse holds part of a worn circular mark. It is worth little money. A character who studies it notices that it feels cooler after a distant boom; no check is necessary, and it need not be important until the players choose to care.

At the hideout, add one sensory beat when water crashes through the cave: the physical boom lands, then a smaller magical pressure follows. Let it pass. Do not name the Echo or alter the published rescue stakes.

Session 1 as played: The five PCs completed Cragmaw Hideout, killed Klarg, and left Yeemik in charge after he released Sildar under their bargain. Sildar traveled with the party. They were told humanoid figures took Gundren but learned no destination. Trista privately kept the BELOW token; Donavan noticed her hide something without learning what it was. Aldric was revived with a hideout potion. After a long rest, the party stopped outside Barthen's Provisions before any delivery or town conversation. See the actual play record for what is known and still open.

DM-only Gundren continuity: The figures were Redbrands. They abducted Gundren and delivered him to Cragmaw Castle. The party now knows that Redbrands have Gundren, but the castle destination has not been reported as learned. This changes the published capture route while preserving the castle destination.

Sessions 2-4: Phandalin and the Black Spider

Redbrands, town relationships, Cragmaw Castle, and the mine remain the campaign's backbone. If a player searches Barthen's papers or Nezznar's discarded notes, offer an optional damaged fragment mentioning *Phandelver*, *resonance*, and *the Spider*. It is a lead, never a prerequisite.

Gundren is Trista's benefactor. He once paid a dangerous debt after she was caught stealing and told her, "Everyone deserves at least one person willing to bet on them." He acquired the medallion without understanding it and intended to consult her. Do not declare when or how Trista receives it until it happens in play. Donavan recognizes that the token's mark resembles a damaged research notation rather than a trade emblem, but its meaning lies outside even his broad academic training. That is a lead for his field notes, not a reason to solve the mystery at level 1.

Sessions 5-7: Wave Echo Cave

At the Forge, the paired pressure becomes unmistakable. Nezznar has independently found the same pattern and recorded: *The echo is not unique. I have heard its twin beneath the mountain beneath the city*. His outcome remains open: he may talk, flee, die, or leave evidence behind.

The party's meaningful interaction with the Forge causes something beneath Waterdeep to respond. Halaster notices, but the players need not watch a cutscene. A recovered map or research note marks Waterdeep: **THE ECHO BELOW**. This earns the transition without explaining the Nine all at once.

Waterdeep: a home that moves the story

Start each return with one welcome, one changed relationship, and no more than two actionable leads. The Yawning Portal gives food, rooms, messages, and Durnan's practical question: "Tell someone when you expect to be back." The Second Margin gives research. Ninepin Works gives careful repair. Blue Lantern Quay gives travel and hard-earned maritime knowledge. Lantern House gives people who feel consequences first.

Waterdeep's recurring faces

Use the detailed Waterdeep Hub as the city chapter. Its eight recurring figures are deliberately distinct:

Person	What they offer	What they want protected
Durnan	a home and grounded judgment	people who leave through the well
Selise Ardent	precise research	careful proof and her students
Mara Vey	criminal access and a personal test for Trista	agency, profit, and not being treated as a lesson
Orren Brassmantle	instruments and repair	consent before destructive testing
Ilvara Reed	civic records and quiet help	sources, civilians, and responsible disclosure
Kestrel Dane	rivalry and expeditions	recognition and her crew
Sister Anja Vale	care and the severance argument	people closest to a failed experiment
Captain Rusk Vess	routes, logistics, and witness accounts	honest rescue plans and sailors' lives

The **Still Hand** wants to isolate or sever the network. Its evidence supports caution: deliberately tuning recovered parts makes the response grow. It does not prove that investigation itself empowers Halaster. Anja's care is real even when her conclusion differs from the party's.

The first Waterdeep sessions

The first supper

Rain rattles the Portal windows. Durnan asks for a return date. Mara joins the table without asking, returns a small item lifted from Trista years ago, and asks after Gundren. The outcome is a home, a relationship, and a reason to visit Selise - no required fight.

The book that remembers

At Second Margin, a blank gray-linen book reacts near the medallion. Selise repeats the experiment openly and asks permission before copying anything. Its text is: **THE FIRST IS BENEATH YOU. THE SECOND ECHOES IN THE MINE. THE THIRD HAS FORGOTTEN HOW TO SPEAK.** A building deed reveals the hidden stair to the Silent Library. Players may enter now, secure it, or prepare first.

A quiet accusation

Later, evidence links a broker behind Mara's theft contract to supplies delivered at Lantern House. Anja presents one documented accident and one uncertain inference in the hospice courtyard. End with a decision about a supervised test, evidence-sharing, or refusal - never a compulsory betrayal scene.

Character spotlights

Trista: the person Gundren bet on

Trista is central through Gundren, Mara, charity, her criminal instincts, and Echo's Whisper. Her oversized monk robes, calm bearing, and watchful eye make her easy to underestimate; the campaign should reward her when she notices what people hide and chooses what to do with it. Mara is not a moral lesson or a compulsory betrayal. Her theft contract creates a fair, visible pressure between loyalty, fear, and value.

Trista's strongest campaign question is: **when something powerful comes into her hands, who does she become responsible for?** Gundren's faith gave her a way forward. The medallion tests whether she can protect a dangerous thing without letting it define her. Let her charity create practical relationships: thank-you notes at the Portal, people willing to testify for her, or a community she has already helped when a later danger reaches it.

Donavan Kemp: the field researcher who must bring knowledge home

Donavan is a 25-year-old Neutral Good human wizard, sage, and field researcher from the **Kemp Archive and Arcane University**, a library and university in an elven metropolis. He has spent seven years gathering reliable accounts from places where the truth is incomplete or inconvenient. He has tousled light-brown hair, green eyes behind narrow dark spectacles, a long walking staff, a crowded scholar's satchel, and a barn owl familiar. He favors black, gold, blue, and purple. The Fey Realm is one of the multiversal places he hopes to explore, not the Archive's home.

His home is not an abstraction. His wife **Dianna Kemp**, a blue tiefling mathematician, teaches at the Archive. His uncle **Favian** taught him that written magic can reveal the ordered structure of the Weave. His mother Vivian and siblings Lilian, Conner, and Nilla remain part of the family institution; his father Markus is dead, while the truth of that death stays open. Donavan's work is aimed toward the Order of Scribes tradition, but this campaign treats every accurate record and hard-won translation as a step toward it rather than handing him a finished answer.

Donavan's strongest campaign question is: **can he pursue a discovery powerful enough to change magic without allowing it to control him?** The Echo and Looking Glass give that question real stakes. He should be the party member who labels claims, compares sources, sketches ruins, and notices who benefits when a record disappears. He is also the person who steps forward when someone with power humiliates or exploits someone weaker.

Donavan Kemp, field researcher of the Kemp Archive

Ringgo Paul: the weapon who chooses what he is for

Ringgo is a 30-year-old tiefling rogue from Baldur's Gate and a former assassin trying to escape the criminal world that trained him. He is tall and solidly built, with purple skin, dark-purple hair, green eyes, studded leather, and the tools of a spy and burglar. His strongest talents are speed, stealth, deception, and reading the practical dangers in a room. He does not begin with secret knowledge of the Echo, the Still Hand, or Halaster.

Ringgo's strongest campaign question is: **can he use the skills that made him dangerous without allowing those skills to decide who he remains?** Give him honest work, people whose trust cannot be bought, and situations where restraint is harder than violence. His former profession may produce contacts, rumors, or recognition in Baldur's Gate, Waterdeep, and Skullport, but no old employer is automatically part of the Still Hand or Halaster's network. Cade chooses the particular contract or event that finally made Ringgo leave; the dock-clerk-and-ledger incident is an optional version, not established history.

Pebble: the mountain beyond the map

Pebble came down from his Goron home because the dwarves who made his hammer described shiny stones that might taste wonderful. The supply escort gives him company and a route toward Phandalin's mines. His fear of getting lost is real, but curiosity usually carries him forward. Let Byron decide what he eats, how he asks for help, and whether the rumored stone turns out to be a mineral, a mistaken tale, or something worth protecting. Do not make Pebble's appetite an automatic way to identify an Echo site or consume a plot-critical artifact.

In Waterdeep, give him places and people that make an unfamiliar city navigable: a reliable meeting place, a craftsperson who appreciates his hammer, and companions who remember his preferred route home. At a distant site, he can choose whether discovery is worth the risk of losing the people who helped him find his way. He meets the other PCs during Session 1; none has a preassigned connection to him.

Aldric Vane: a second life and an unfinished debt

Aldric was a Crown battle mage and magistrate who obeyed orders that harmed innocents while his family was threatened. After he worked against the Crown, he was killed and returned as a Reborn with broken memories. His signet ring, dread of smoke, and longing for faces he cannot picture are personal facts; the Crown's identity, the cause of his return, and any connection to the Echo remain open. Bowman decides when the party learns his history and what atonement means in play.

Give him chances to protect people without repeating the Crown's methods, and records that might eventually help recover his family's names. Waterdeep's archives and civic contacts can be leads if Bowman pursues them. His old battle instincts may make overwhelming magic tempting, but never force that choice or turn the other PCs into judges of his redemption. At level 1 he is a Wizard preparing for Evocation; he gains that school at level 2 under the campaign's 2014 rules.

The shared story

All five characters give the party different reasons to care about the same mystery. Pebble and Aldric joined in Session 1. Pebble's search for a delicious shiny rock and fear of getting lost can open a personal thread; Aldric’s fragmented memories and atonement can become a spotlight, but Bowman decides when to reveal them. Do not make the Crown or his return from death secretly part of the Echo by default. Trista understands that an object can become personal before its history is known. Donavan understands that an artifact's history affects everyone who may be harmed by its use. Ringgo understands that information can become a weapon before anyone admits they are wielding it. None gets final authority: Trista decides what she will carry; Donavan decides what he will publish or hold back; Ringgo decides which methods he will refuse to repeat; the party decides together what they will risk.

Give the five PCs a road scene before the ambush. Gundren asks Donavan to keep an honest account of anything unusual at the mine, asks Trista to make sure he returns to read it, and asks Ringgo to choose the safest camp rather than the fastest one. Later, at the Silent Library, Donavan's catalogue work, Trista's eye for hidden access, and Ringgo's route discipline produce several valid approaches: preserve the archive in place, rescue its fragile record, or secure a path for later study. None is automatically right.

PanikStrikez25 controls whether Trista accepts custody of Echo's Whisper when it is recovered. Brodey can decide the barn owl's name, the reason for Donavan's spectacles and staff, the truth of Markus's death, and the discovery Donavan most fears to share with the Archive. Cade decides Ringgo's breaking-point contract, the

people from his old life who still matter, and how openly he names his former profession. Reserve the Hollow Mountain for a consequence that grows from actual play, not a predetermined family secret.

Mechanical source of truth

Each live character sheet is authoritative for that character's mechanics. Trista uses her 2024 Monk sheet. Ringgo's current sheet uses legacy rogue and tiefling features while displaying 2024 Nick and Vex labels; ignore those mastery properties unless the DM explicitly grants Weapon Mastery. Donavan follows his own live sheet. Mixed rules versions are allowed, but any conversion or harmonization must be an explicit table decision rather than a silent rewrite.

Advancement and the long shape

Use milestones: level 1 at the start; roughly level 5 after Wave Echo Cave; then growth through substantial accomplishments across Undermountain and satellite journeys, reaching 17-20 at the finale. Dungeon floor numbers are not character levels. The Undermountain roadmap overlays the published adventure without replacing its maps, inhabitants, or room keys.

The six satellite adventures cover Sites 3-8. They are expandable two-session excursions with fail-forward clues and choices that affect later options. Site 9, the Hollow Mountain, remains intentionally unlocated until the party makes it meaningful.

Waterdeep: the home worth returning to

Campaign Bible expansion • DM edition • Includes secrets

Visual references: Recurring cast · Locations and Echo's Whisper · Generation prompts and art notes. The location plate reveals the hidden archive; show it selectively. Incidental lettering in the artwork does not establish additional lore.

Waterdeep is where the characters build lives worth coming back to. Undermountain provides the central mystery; the city supplies friendship, rivalries, practical help, and choices about what that mystery should become.

Continuity and source key

BOOK means published setting/adventure material. **ESTABLISHED** means custom material recovered from "DND Campaign Help." **NEW** means campaign additions developed in this chapter. All unmarked NPC secrets, dialogue, businesses, relationships, clues, and progression below are NEW. They are not claims about published lore. Character levels below are suggested timing, not dungeon-floor numbers.

BOOK: Durnan operates the Yawning Portal, whose well provides entry into Undermountain. Halaster and the dungeon belong to *Waterdeep: Dungeon of the Mad Mage*. Its dungeon history supplies the knot in the Weave; the Echo network is our interpretation layered onto that foundation. Keep the adventure's room descriptions, residents, travel restrictions, and rules unless deliberately modifying them. The Harpers are a published faction; Ilvara and this local operation are custom.

ESTABLISHED: Lost Mine of Phandelver > Waterdeep > Dungeon of the Mad Mage; milestone advancement; Waterdeep is home. The Echo is resonance produced by the knot. There are **nine total sites: Undermountain plus eight satellites**. Sites are not a portal network. Halaster identified them without visiting all of them. Nezznar independently follows research and does not serve Halaster. Gundren is Trista's benefactor; he acquired the black stone medallion without understanding it. Mara likes Trista but steals because she can, rather than to help others, and receives a contract to steal the medallion.

Continuity correction already adopted in the prior conversation: retire the early one-plus-nine and one-plus-twenty-three versions of the medallion. Use one center plus eight surrounding circles everywhere. If a twenty-three-part dungeon diagram has already appeared at the table, treat it as a separate dungeon survey, not a different form of the Nine symbol.

Party now established: Trista, Pebble, Donavan Kemp, Ringgo Paul, and Aldric Vane are the current five-person party. Preserve the player-held details still marked open in the continuity reference rather than treating any character as unfinished. The Hollow Mountain's location and personal connection remain open. Echo's Whisper's mechanical powers remain subject to balancing. Looking Glass was designed to amplify the knot; why it was abandoned and the exact consequences of completing it remain mysteries. Do not establish a mandatory ending or make every NPC secretly serve Halaster.

Eight recurring faces

1. Durnan - the person who expects you back

Status: BOOK NPC; the following relationships, scenes, and progression are NEW. **Role:** innkeeper, home-base anchor, experienced observer. **Base/home:** the Yawning Portal; use its published layout for private quarters.

Appearance direction: broad, weathered human man, dark hair threaded with gray, plain working clothes, economical movement. His hands stop polishing a tankard before his expression changes. This is campaign art direction, not an exact reproduction of official art.

Personality and voice: dry, practical, observant; kindness expressed through food and preparedness. “Tell someone when you expect to be back.” He dislikes bragging about casualties and respects people who retrieve someone else’s pack.

Relationships: trusts Vess’s judgment about expeditions; allows Kestrel’s crew to boast until they torment novices; knows Mara is trouble but does not confuse suspicion with proof. He comes to trust the PCs through their conduct, not their wealth.

DM secret: he has heard the party’s peculiar two-beat description from previous survivors. He kept a page from an abandoned expedition log because its owner never returned. He does not know what the Nine mean.

Clue: the log records an anomalous pulse below the well, corroborating Site 1. A later margin entry mentions a traveler comparing the pulse to a flooded coastal ruin: a backup lead to Site 4.

Progression: levels 5-8, he learns their names and stores a sealed emergency letter; 9-14, he reserves their usual table and notices when their behavior changes; 15-20, he helps organize shelter and supplies if the city is threatened. He does not descend to solve their campaign.

First scene: he asks for a return date, then puts an extra bowl on the table for the companion still washing dungeon blood off their hands. **Pressure:** a frightened survivor wants the well closed. Durnan asks the party for evidence and a practical response.

2. Selise Ardent - the scholar decoding the Nine

Status: NEW. **Role:** translator, cartographic historian, careful theorist. **Base/home:** The Second Margin bookshop in the Castle Ward; a cramped room above it and access to the Starcup Roof.

Appearance: older brown-skinned human woman; silver braid, brass spectacles, indigo shawl, ink on two fingers. Her desk has three trays marked observed, inferred, and disputed.

Personality and voice: delighted by precision, embarrassed by praise, fiercely protective of students. “That is an excellent theory. What would prove it wrong?” She can explain inscriptions, but cannot conjure answers without evidence.

Relationships: Orren tests her theories; Ilvara supplies records but wants names redacted; Anja helped her through an illness. Selise thinks Mara’s provenance stories are terrible and buys useful documents anyway.

DM secret: a mentor’s disappearance led her to buy this shop. An old floor plan has a room that the current building lacks. She has not found the Silent Library and does not know its society’s fate.

Clues: a blank book reacts near Echo's Whisper, showing the established first/second/third inscription. Building deeds locate the missing staircase. Her dated tower sketches lead to Site 7; inconsistent star observations point toward Site 8.

Progression: 5-8, establishes that the mark describes a relationship rather than a noble crest; the Silent Library confirms nine sites. 9-14, distinguishes a site waking from several sites synchronizing. 15-20, prepares a comparative dossier for the party's final decision, explicitly marking uncertainty.

First scene: she asks permission to copy the medallion rather than reaching for it. **Pressure:** a wealthy sponsor offers to fund her work in exchange for exclusive access. The party can offer alternatives; accepting sponsorship does not automatically make her a traitor.

3. Mara Vey - the friend who might take it

Status: ESTABLISHED character and theft contract; appearance, employer, and local details NEW. **Role:** Trista's criminal contact, temptation, information broker. **Base/home:** a rented attic above the custom Red Sash mending shop in the Dock Ward; meetings on the Blue Lantern Quay or in a public booth at the Portal.

Appearance: lean human woman in her thirties, olive skin, short dark waves, eyebrow scar, charcoal coat, burgundy scarf. Her jewelry is inexpensive; her boots are excellent.

Personality and voice: playful, incisive, unsentimental about property. "You give it away. I call that skipping the best part." She genuinely enjoys Trista and resents being treated as a moral lesson.

Relationships: former partner of Trista; occasionally sells to Orren; trades favors with Vess. Ilvara keeps her at arm's length. A broker associated with Anja's secret faction offers the medallion contract; Mara initially knows only the broker.

DM secret: the price is extravagantly high for something the client calls dangerous junk. Mara investigates before committing to delivery. She is not secretly responsible for Gundren's earlier troubles.

Clues: the contract's packaging instructions specify ceramic insulation and suppression of vibration. A warehouse receipt connects the broker to hospice deliveries. Her stolen salvage list supplies a second route to Site 4 and an auction entry supplies Site 6's expedition journal.

Progression: 5-8, reunites with Trista and probes what the medallion does; 9-14, the contract forces a choice between profit, loyalty, and fear; 15-20, she may become a trusted smuggler, an estranged rival, or a negotiable opponent. Decide from play, not a compulsory betrayal.

First scene: she returns a small object she lifted from Trista years ago, then asks about Gundren. **Run the theft fairly:** show the offer, surveillance, or questions first; resolve any attempt through play. Never declare an unavoidable offscreen loss of the signature item.

4. Orren Brassmantle - the expert who asks what an item costs its owner

Status: NEW. **Role:** magic-item examiner, repairer, maker of research instruments. **Base/home:** Ninepin Works in the Trades Ward; family living rooms above the workshop.

Appearance: stocky dwarf man, copper-brown skin, auburn beard threaded with ceramic beads, leather apron, jeweler's loupe. Brass tools sit in felt-lined drawers; delicate objects rest on ceramic rather than metal.

Personality and voice: patient, tactile, quietly funny. "I can tell you what it does. Why someone made it is a different invoice." He refuses destructive tests without consent.

Relationships: Selise's friendly intellectual sparring partner; repairs Vess's instruments; buys legitimate salvage from Kestrel. He admires Anja's medical work and does not know who funds some of her orders.

DM secret: he has already built ceramic damping housings for a buyer who claimed they were medical equipment. Their measurements match the medallion's diameter. He kept the order because it was unusually specific.

Clues: forge residue from Site 2 and the medallion produce related responses under controlled comparison. His invoice corroborates Mara's contract. A recovered star-glass sample points to Site 8 only after Selise compares it to observations.

Progression: 5-8, records the dormant/awakened appearance without granting new powers; 9-14, builds a limited research apparatus that compares samples locally; 15-20, helps prototype a sealing or retuning component chosen by the PCs. No device becomes a universal detector or instant shutdown button.

First scene: he asks Trista to keep hold of the cord while he examines the stone. **Pressure:** a profitable commission would require sacrificing an irreplaceable artifact. He wants a second opinion, not someone to make his decision for him.

5. Ilvara Reed - a faction ally with boundaries

Status: NEW representative of the published Harpers; this mission is custom. **Role:** records access, discreet investigation, civic consequences. **Base:** a rented office at the custom Reed & Ledger copying house in the Castle Ward. **Home:** an ordinary rented North Ward apartment; its address is not a reward for faction service.

Appearance: middle-aged dark-skinned half-elf woman, cropped curls, blue-gray traveling coat, silver harp pin worn inside her lapel.

Personality and voice: composed, direct, suspicious of grand solutions. "Who benefits if we believe this?" She respects refusals and requests reciprocal discretion.

Relationships: supplies Selise with copies; regards Mara as a source rather than a recruit; has paid Kestrel for a rescue. She trusts Anja's patient care but questions unexplained supply purchases.

DM secret: reports of magical anomalies have been diverted through a false clerical routing order. She suspects a leak but has no grounds to accuse a named person. This is a local breach, not proof that the Harpers are compromised as a whole.

Clues: witness statements locate Site 5's affected valley; travel records corroborate Site 6; reports of the same impossible tower at different dates help locate Site 7. She supplies mundane records for Site 9 only once play establishes its personal connection.

Progression: 5-8, offers one bounded information exchange; 9-14, entrusts the party with sources and civilian consequences; 15-20, can coordinate allies and evacuation if relationships support it. Faction membership is optional and confers no immunity from city law.

First scene: asks them to recover a missing surveyor's notebook, not swear an oath. **Pressure:** publishing the network map might expose people living near its sites. Give the PCs a meaningful choice about redaction.

6. Kestrel Dane - captain of the Gilded Compass

Status: NEW. **Role:** recurring rival expedition leader; the principal face of a small supporting party. **Base/home:** rented rooms at the Yawning Portal and a shared storage shed near the docks.

Appearance: young adult human woman, freckled tan skin, tied-back red hair, dented blue breastplate, a gold cloth strip at her shoulder. Her smile is confident; her repaired equipment betrays a thin budget.

Personality and voice: competitive, generous in public, afraid of being ordinary. “Second back buys breakfast.” She wants recognition and reliable pay, not the PCs’ deaths.

The Gilded Compass: Kestrel handles negotiation and the front line. Pell, a soft-spoken halfling scout in a moss cloak, sketches routes and argues for retreat. Nym, a copper-scaled dragonborn wizard in patched plum robes, catalogs objects and hates breaking them. These are supporting faces, keeping the core recurring cast at eight. All wear a small brass compass badge with one bent point; it is unrelated to the Nine.

Relationships: Durnan monitors their bravado; Orren buys salvage; Vess once rescued them from a disastrous charter. Kestrel envies the PCs’ attention from Selise while liking the party more than she intended.

DM secret: she sold the original northern expedition journal to pay for an injured companion’s treatment, retaining a partial copy. She bluffs about the copy being complete.

Clues: the copy launches Site 6; dates in Pell’s travel sketches independently corroborate Site 7. If the players miss the Silent Library lead, Nym asks why a purchased book contains numbered blank pages.

Progression: 5-8, friendly contests and rumors; 9-14, a failed expedition makes cooperation necessary; 15-20, they can secure an evacuation route or handle a secondary objective while the PCs confront the central threat. They never clear a major site offscreen or steal a climax.

First scene: Kestrel offers a wager on who returns with the strangest harmless souvenir. **Pressure:** a sponsor demands an artifact be delivered unopened. Kestrel wants the party to examine it without publicly embarrassing her.

7. Sister Anja Vale - compassion with a dangerous conclusion

Status: NEW. **Role:** healer, community anchor, hidden link to the faction that wants the network destroyed. **Base/home:** Lantern House, a custom charitable hospice in the Southern Ward; a small cell beside its herb courtyard. “Sister” is a community title; her faith can be chosen later without redefining a published temple.

Appearance: older human woman, weathered pale face, gray bun, cream clothing and moss-green stole. She looks tired and approachable. Do not visually telegraph a villain.

Personality and voice: attentive, unhurried, uncomfortably persuasive. “Tell me who would be standing nearest when it fails.” Her care for patients is real.

Relationships: nursed Selise; buys Orren’s damping housings through a broker; has treated Kestrel’s companions. She recognizes Trista’s charitable motives and offers sincere ways to help.

DM secret: Anja belongs to the **Still Hand**, the new name for the established anti-network faction. She supplies testimony and refuge; its acquisition broker issues Mara’s contract. She knows of the purchase but initially not the intended thief. Years ago she treated survivors of a resonance accident whose cause remains incompletely understood. Halaster did not secretly engineer her life.

Clues: patient accounts of shared dreams lead to Site 5. Her notes distinguish ancient sealing methods at Site 6 from the modern Still Hand; the faction did not necessarily build that seal. Her supplies and a duplicate phrase in the contract expose the organizational link.

Progression: 5-8, trusted healer and advocate; 9-14, evidence reveals the affiliation and she argues for severance; 15-20, she can support a tested safer alternative or oppose the party's plan through disclosed, consequential action. Her reaction depends on their evidence and conduct.

First scene: asks for clean bandages and assistance delivering food before requesting any artifact. **Pressure:** her faction wants to destroy a component she believes might also protect patients. She can dissent. She will not poison patients or make lifesaving care conditional on allegiance.

8. Captain Rusk Vess - the way back to the wider world

Status: NEW. **Role:** transport contact, witness, practical expedition planner. **Base:** Blue Lantern Quay in the Dock Ward. **Home:** her cutter, the *Patient Gull*.

Appearance: older broad half-orc woman, gray-green skin, salt-white braid, one brass-capped tusk, navy wool coat. Her charts smell of cloves and tar.

Personality and voice: blunt, superstitious about small things, rational about large dangers. "A map is what someone survived long enough to write down." She negotiates terms openly.

Relationships: long-standing acquaintance of Durnan; occasional transport for Mara; protective of Kestrel's inexperienced crew; brings Orren broken compasses.

DM secret: she lost a friend near the Drowned Observatory and falsified the public position to deter treasure hunters. She retains the true bearings. Earning her trust means presenting a rescue and return plan, not winning one persuasion roll.

Clues: the true log, a recovered brass star plate, and the tides together give a usable route to Site 4. A later fisher's account locates one appearance of Site 7. She can arrange the first leg north for Site 6, not deliver the party directly to the glacier.

Progression: 5-8, sells information and modest passage; 9-14, becomes an expedition partner; 15-20, directs ordinary transport and relief work while heroes handle extraordinary threats. Planar travel remains beyond her vessel's normal capabilities.

First scene: asks the party to explain why a compass recovered from a wreck points down. **Pressure:** a creditor wants her ship. Resolving that problem creates loyalty without an Echo revelation.

The hub as a playable place

All businesses and interiors below are NEW except the Yawning Portal itself. Ward placements are campaign placements, not published street addresses. These are a relationship network, not a scale city map.

Yawning Portal, Castle Ward

What the players experience: Warm bread, wet wool, rope creak, a well too dark for the room's cheerful noise

Services and actionable detail: Lodging, meals, messages, descent arrangements; meet Durnan and the Compass

How it changes: Their rented rooms acquire souvenirs, letters, and a table everyone recognizes

The Second Margin, Castle Ward

What the players experience: Rain on green bay windows, crowded books, a cold draft under a shelf

Services and actionable detail: Selise's research; a deed identifies the concealed staircase to Site 3

How it changes: One research desk becomes a shared map room; the archive remains a separate site beneath the shop

Ninepin Works, Trades Ward

What the players experience: Brass filings, felt-lined trays, a tuning fork that stops too quickly

Services and actionable detail: Orren examines or repairs recovered objects; keeps signed receipts

How it changes: Safe local experiments make the workshop useful without turning it into unlimited magic-item stock

Blue Lantern Quay, Dock Ward

What the players experience: Blue glass lanterns, black water, gulls, wet steps

Services and actionable detail: Vess's ship and logs; access to sailors and coastal expeditions

How it changes: Reputation changes the terms of passage; rescued sailors bring new reports

Red Sash, Dock Ward

What the players experience: A busy mending shop; one upstairs window never lit twice in a row

Services and actionable detail: Mara's dead drop behind a removable stair tread; arrange meetings through a mundane stitched ribbon

How it changes: Mara's presence or absence signals relationship changes, not automatic betrayal

Reed & Ledger, Castle Ward

What the players experience: Dry paper, meticulous copies, a locked interview room

Services and actionable detail: Ilvara's appointments and redacted records; mundane legal and travel research

How it changes: A trusted contact allows introductions, not free access to all faction intelligence

Lantern House, Southern Ward

What the players experience: Stew, clean linen, herbs, an open courtyard

Services and actionable detail: Care, volunteering, Anja's patient testimonies; sealed supply cupboard

How it changes: Expanding care demonstrates the value of the city; faction tension can divide staff without making them conspirators

Starcup Roof, above Second Margin

What the players experience: Laundry below a brass telescope; chimney smoke crossing the stars

Services and actionable detail: Selise's night observations; compare star glass and tower sightings

How it changes: Early curious evenings become collaborative research, then a place to discuss what must be saved

Making the Yawning Portal home

Start with rented rooms and an ordinary shared table. After the party returns reliably and treats staff well, Durnan offers a standing booking and a lockable storage chest on normal negotiated terms. Later they can rent an adjoining room as a briefing room. These are campaign additions, not ownership of the inn or a magical safe zone.

Give each character a visible personal space: a shelf, a hook for equipment, a letter tucked into a doorframe. Trista's can accumulate thank-you notes from people she helped. Donavan's can collect labeled field notes, letters from Dianna, and a perch for his owl. Ringgo's begins spare and defensible: a clear view of the door, a place for tools, and one ordinary possession he chooses to leave in sight. Let later additions show when he begins to believe he is staying.

Use three recurring rituals: Durnan asks their expected return date; someone notices a new scar or souvenir; the party chooses who gets the first story over dinner. Most returns should be restful. Reserve home-base danger for an earned major escalation, rather than repeated burglaries and hostage plots.

Return travel still follows the dungeon's actual access and magic restrictions. The Echo does not give a convenient teleport home. Summarize a secured route when appropriate; revisit it when control or hazards have materially changed.

The Nine: Waterdeep clue ledger

Site names, order, broad locations, statuses, and level bands below are ESTABLISHED. All specific Waterdeep clues are NEW. Each row has three independent routes; they may converge on the same destination but should not require the same NPC, item, or skill check. Give the essential lead when characters investigate a sensible source. Rolls can improve precision, reduce expense, or reveal danger.

1. Undermountain - Prime Echo / 5+ / active

First Waterdeep lead: Durnan's survivor log names the well

Independent corroboration: Nezznar's recovered research points below Waterdeep

Recovery route if missed: Another returning explorer describes the paired pulse

Payoff and meaningful decision: Stronger response confirms the connection; choose what to disclose before descending

2. Wave Echo Cave - Forge / already encountered / active

First Waterdeep lead: Compare the party's records with Selise's diagram

Independent corroboration: Orren examines a legitimately obtained forge sample

Recovery route if missed: Gundren's letter or surviving mine records, according to actual play

Payoff and meaningful decision: Protect ties to Phandalin; decide whether outside researchers receive access

3. Silent Library / 6-8 / dormant

First Waterdeep lead: Blank book reacts near the medallion

Independent corroboration: Building deed reveals an inaccessible basement room

Recovery route if missed: Nym's numbered blank pages carry the former society's address

Payoff and meaningful decision: Confirm nine total sites; study or wake the archive without assuming activation is mandatory

4. Drowned Observatory / 8-10 / unstable

First Waterdeep lead: Vess's bearings and tide notes

Independent corroboration: Mara's salvage manifest records the same offshore recovery

Recovery route if missed: Durnan's log identifies a surviving coastal witness

Payoff and meaningful decision: Recover Halaster's established "unsuitable" warning; investigate why before attempting stabilization

5. Dead God's Scar / 10-12 / corrupted

First Waterdeep lead: Anja's patients report matching dreams and the same valley

Independent corroboration: Ilvara's surveyor statements

Recovery route if missed: A temple's public travel-and-burial record, obtained without Anja

Payoff and meaningful decision: Decide how to protect residents while examining divine contamination; leave the divine identity open for PCs

6. Frozen Door / 12-14 / sealed

First Waterdeep lead: Kestrel's partial expedition journal

Independent corroboration: Mara's auction record locates the original

Recovery route if missed: Ilvara's caravan records plus the surviving expedition member's testimony

Payoff and meaningful decision: Discover an older deliberate seal; decide whether opening it is justified

7. Walking Tower / 14-16 / mobile

First Waterdeep lead: Selise aligns repeated architectural sketches

Independent corroboration: Pell's dated route drawings

Recovery route if missed: Vess's fisher witness reports its latest appearance

Payoff and meaningful decision: Track its next appearance; obtain a Looking Glass fragment without making the tower a universal transport service

8. Broken Star / 16-18 / extremely unstable

First Waterdeep lead: Starcup observations disagree with terrestrial bearings

Independent corroboration: Orren's star-glass sample responds anomalously

Recovery route if missed: An independently recovered Undermountain research fragment describes the same optical effect

Payoff and meaningful decision: Establish the need for planar investigation; these clues do not themselves provide a planar-travel spell

9. Hollow Mountain / 18-20 / unknown

First Waterdeep lead: Selise finds an unresolved ninth index with no coordinates

Independent corroboration: Ilvara finds a matching record only after its personal connection is chosen

Recovery route if missed: The medallion's empty ninth mark fills when the established late-game trigger occurs

Payoff and meaningful decision: Choose the player-created connection before preparing coordinates; determine who can be trusted with the location Halaster lacks

Site 3 book text, preserved: "THE FIRST IS BENEATH YOU. THE SECOND ECHOES IN THE MINE. THE THIRD HAS FORGOTTEN HOW TO SPEAK." A rubbing, a recovered catalogue, or local research can carry the investigation if the medallion is unavailable. The item makes discovery personal, not exclusive to Trista.

Information pacing: a rumor, a probable destination, and a safe approach are different rewards. Early access to a northern journal need not make its expedition safe at level 6. Likewise, do not forbid players from following an early lead; communicate practical dangers and let their preparations matter.

The Still Hand and the argument against activation

ESTABLISHED: a third faction wants the network destroyed and argues that the party may be completing Halaster's work. **NEW:** its name, organization, evidence, and internal disagreements.

The Still Hand wants to sever the connections between sites and the Prime Echo. It does not need to destroy the Weave itself, and it does not know how to remove the knot. Its public-facing members support research into magical accidents. Its small acquisition cell buys, steals, and suppresses dangerous components. Anja favors informed agreement and sealing; a harder wing favors irreversible destruction. Avoid assigning every suspicious person to it.

Their strongest evidence is a controlled local experiment: when two recovered components are deliberately tuned together, the measured response grows. That supports concern about synchronization. It does **not** prove that examining a ruin or carrying the medallion empowers Halaster. Their missing evidence is what the complete network would do and whether reversible isolation can prevent it.

Reveal Anja through three observable clues: Orren's duplicate specification, a delivery receipt tied to the acquisition broker, and her possession of a matching suppression diagram. Each alone has an innocent explanation; together they justify a conversation. She admits her affiliation when presented with credible evidence. Insight is not a mind-reading shortcut.

Her confrontation line: "If we are wrong, we lose a discovery. If you are wrong, who loses their home?" Selise answers that ignorance also has costs. Orren proposes a bounded experiment. Ilvara asks who will oversee it. Mara asks what everyone is willing to pay. Let the players decide which argument survives scrutiny.

Track choices without fixing the ending

For each site, record: condition, people affected, knowledge recovered, custody of components, and connection state. Connection states are **unexamined, observed, deliberately tuned, isolated, or severed**. This is NEW DM bookkeeping, not a player-facing subsystem or settled cosmology.

Studying a site can provide leverage and safer options. Deliberate tuning can make its power available to an amplification attempt. Isolation removes that connection while the seal holds. Severance removes it more permanently but can destroy knowledge or damage local interests. Removing a component may suppress or destabilize a site; determine and foreshadow that site's behavior before the choice, rather than using a surprise punishment.

At the finale, translate actual decisions into available allies, shutdown options, missing power sources, and exposed civilians. Do not impose numerical encounter modifiers until the party's level and the final design are known. Preserve destroy, complete, rewrite, and confrontation possibilities.

Campaign progression and first visits

Arrival, levels 5-6: introduce Durnan, Mara, and Selise in separate scenes. Nezznar's evidence gives a reason to consult Selise; Durnan offers the practical way down; Mara brings the personal past. Do not deliver all nine site names at once.

First return, levels 6-8: warm meal, one party-specific letter, and the blank-book reaction. Meet Orren through a need for examination. The Gilded Compass returns with a different account of familiar dangers. Investigating the Silent Library establishes the Nine; Vess offers the next wider-world possibility.

Middle campaign, levels 9-14: Ilvara connects discoveries to people outside the dungeon. Anja is already someone the party has helped before her affiliation becomes relevant. Reveal the theft contract and allow a response before it is resolved. Keep Looking Glass's abandonment reveal tied to the established dungeon roadmap; city research contextualizes it rather than prematurely replacing it.

Late campaign, levels 15-20: Selise and Orren interpret evidence the PCs recovered, including the amplification finding scheduled for the deep dungeon. The hub becomes a council of distinct interests rather than a unanimous quest-giving committee. Bind Site 9 to an actual player-created relationship or consequence. Halaster still has not reached it.

On each return, prepare one welcome, one changed relationship, and at most two actionable leads. Advance consequences when enough in-world time passes or player actions cause them. Do not force every visit into a new emergency.

Three ready-to-run scenes

The first supper: rain rattles the shutters while a basket descends into the well. Mara sits at the party's table without asking. Durnan puts down bread and asks when they expect to return. If Trista carries the medallion by then, Mara notices it but asks about Gundren first. Donavan notices Mara measuring everyone's reactions; Ringgo notices the exits she kept open. Outcome: a home, three character beats, and a reason to visit Selise; no mandatory fight.

The book that remembers: at Second Margin, words appear when the medallion passes a blank page. Selise asks everyone to remain still and repeats the test. A building deed provides the hidden room's location. The party chooses whether to investigate now, secure the entrance, or return after preparing. No failed roll erases the discovery.

A quiet accusation: after the contract comes to light, Anja invites a conversation in the hospice courtyard. Patients continue eating nearby. She presents one documented accident and one uncertain inference; Mara can identify the broker. The scene ends with a choice about evidence-sharing, a supervised test, or refusal, not a compulsory betrayal battle.

Equal spotlight

Trista: Gundren and Mara make the mystery personal; Durnan respects reliability; Anja recognizes her charity. Her question is what responsibility comes with holding something powerful. She is never the only person who can interpret evidence or decide the network's fate.

Donavan: Selise challenges the precision of his claims, Orren turns theory into consent-based experiments, and Ilvara asks what responsible disclosure looks like when records can endanger sources. Dianna and the Kemp Archive keep his idea of home alive without solving field problems for him.

Ringgo: Mara understands the utility and danger of criminal skill, Ilvara offers a model of secrets used to protect rather than control, Vess values return plans over bravado, and Kestrel can become a rival who trusts his scouting. Anja can challenge him with the human cost of expedient methods. These are new relationships, not proof that any NPC was his former handler. Skullport may echo his old world without revealing the same organization behind every crime.

Use at least one character-specific welcome or choice on each return, rotating focus. Leave Site 9 unassigned until a relationship, promise, failure, or victory created in play makes it matter to the whole party.

Visual bible

Shared language: Waterdeep is rain-dark slate, warm timber, worn brass, cream paper, and inhabited rooms. Echo effects use restrained violet-gray light and doubled shadows. Warm human spaces should remain visually distinct from cold resonance imagery. Generated plates are campaign concept art, not official portraits, canonical maps, or scale battle maps.

Echo symbol: one larger central circle; exactly eight smaller circles arranged around it, linked by eight fine spokes. The center is Site 1. Starting at the top and moving clockwise, the satellites represent Sites 2-9; the upper-left satellite is therefore Site 9. This positional convention is NEW and diagrams relationships, not geographical bearings. Seven satellite centers contain muted inlay; Site 9's is hollow. A filled inlay means recorded identity, not present activation: glow and annotation indicate observed activity separately. No decorative border circles that can be mistaken for extra sites.

Echo's Whisper: established black stone medallion, palm-small; NEW art direction gives it a worn cord, shallow silver-gray inlay, one chipped lower edge, and a smooth unlettered reverse. It looks handled, not jewel-encrusted. Dormant: no glow. Awakened: a brief paired glimmer. Resonant: a matching known mark responds faintly during a site encounter. Final form: leave exact transformation open; preserve the established moment when Site 9 fills. These are appearance cues, not added mechanical powers. Do not depict it as a portal key or automatic destination finder.

Trista: preserve her established human appearance: 5'8", pale skin, straight brown hair, brown eyes, oversized monk-style robes, calm bearing. Once she carries the medallion, it is usually tucked under the robe. Do not redesign her as an armored assassin to match Mara.

Other props: the BELOW token is rough dark stone with the single word and a partial, worn mark; the blank book is gray linen with no ominous title; Orren's comparator uses brass tuning forks and removable ceramic cups; a Still Hand document bears a single short horizontal bar crossing an open arc, visibly distinct from the Nine. The Gilded Compass badge has a bent compass point, not the resonance symbol.

Silent Library: empty desks, pale dust undisturbed by footsteps in selected areas, book spines without titles, a circular reading table. Silence is an authored site phenomenon, not a blanket assumption that all spells fail.

Future site silhouettes, preserving established concepts: the Drowned Observatory has a broken bronze dome beneath green-black water; the Scar is a pale wound across an otherwise living valley, with the divine identity undecided; the Frozen Door is a lone black doorway in a glacier; the Walking Tower is recognizable by an asymmetrical stepped crown wherever it appears; the Broken Star is a fractured luminous mass with conflicting horizons; the Hollow Mountain remains a deliberately incomplete silhouette, without landmarks that would settle its location.

Sources and use notes

Campaign continuity: the full recent turns of DND Campaign Help, including the Nine Sites, Campaign Bible, Trista/Mara material, and dungeon roadmap. Later explicit revisions take precedence over early drafts.

Published reference: Waterdeep: Dungeon of the Mad Mage, especially Undermountain Overview > Dungeon History and The Yawning Portal. The publicly accessible contents verifies the structure; this chapter does not reproduce room keys or claim new Echo material appears in the book.

Official supporting reference: Durnan's Warning supports his innkeeper role and the Portal descent; Tales from the Yawning Portal introductory excerpt supports the inn as a gathering place for adventurers and distant rumors. Editorial alternative endings and fan theories have not been promoted to published adventure canon.

Next-session record: date; party level; elapsed city time; NPC relationship changes; clues learned; claims still unproven; each site's connection state; promises and contracts; whereabouts of Echo's Whisper; next two leads. Keep this DM document private; the portrait and environment plates omit the Still Hand reveal.

Faces of home

The eight recurring faces of Waterdeep. Campaign visual references; written character entries govern identity and detail.

Places and the signature relic

Places, textures, and Echo's Whisper. Contains the hidden archive; reveal individual references only when the party discovers them.

Waterdeep: city orientation

Campaign orientation map. Custom locations and illustrative streets support play; this is not a precise navigational chart.

The party's city

A closer view of the party's Waterdeep connections. Use the written ward placements and hub entries for authoritative details.

Field adventures: the Nine

DM edition • Sites 3-8 • Companion to the Waterdeep hub

Continuity: the site names, order, suggested character levels, broad concepts, and starting conditions are established. **Everything else in these adventures is NEW campaign development:** room keys, hazards, named locals, handouts, rewards, mechanisms, and proposed consequences. These are original overlays, not published *Dungeon of the Mad Mage* encounters. They do not replace its room keys or travel restrictions.

The Echo is resonance from the knot in the Weave. There are nine sites total, including Undermountain. These sites are **not a portal network**. Investigation never requires tuning or activating them. Halaster identified sites without personally visiting all of them. Looking Glass was designed to amplify the knot; its abandonment and the full consequences of completion remain unresolved. Do not use an invented local clue to answer those questions ahead of the campaign's established dungeon discoveries.

Running these adventures: each is approximately two sessions, expandable with travel and return scenes. DCs are suggested for the five-character party of Trista, Pebble, Donavan Kemp, Ringgo Paul, and Aldric Vane; reassess after major level or sheet changes. Checks buy safety, time, or detail. Essential evidence is available through a sensible action even when a roll fails. Describe hazards before their triggers; never trap everyone behind one failed roll. Damage occurs at most once per failed attempt, cannot repeat while characters pause, and can always be avoided by withdrawing. Clever equipment, a relevant spell, or a convincing physical solution can replace a roll. None of these sites requires combat or a specific class.

Full-party integration: at every site, offer different kinds of useful work without making any one character mandatory. Trista spots concealed access, evaluates valuables, and sees who bears a cost. Donavan establishes provenance, compares claims, and defines what evidence can support. Ringgo scouts routes, tests security assumptions, and identifies when an efficient method would endanger someone else. Pebble can examine stonework, brace equipment, and help others move safely. Aldric can compare magical dangers and choose restrained solutions without revealing his private past. Rotate which contribution opens the scene, and let collaboration replace a roll when their preparations genuinely solve the problem.

For each site, record its starting condition separately from the party's choice: unexamined, observed, deliberately tuned, isolated, or severed. No reward below grants new powers to Echo's Whisper. Inscriptions, copies, and local instruments provide alternatives if the medallion is absent.

Site 3 - The Silent Library

Established frame: Waterdeep; dormant; suggested levels 6-8. This archive lies beneath The Second Margin. Its discovery confirms nine total sites. The former society's fate remains open.

Objective: recover a legible catalogue and understand what the Nine diagram records. Selise supplies the building deed and asks the party to preserve provenance: copy where each page was found before moving it. Donavan recognizes the Archive's same fieldwork principle - a discovery loses meaning when its context is destroyed - but the Library's notation is unfamiliar. A full afternoon of investigation suffices; waking the archive is optional.

> *The stair ends beneath a shop that no longer seems to exist. Overhead, footsteps cease halfway across the ceiling. Dust covers empty desks and a circular reading table. Every book spine is blank. When your lantern moves, each chair casts two shadows - but only one follows the flame.*

1. The forgotten stair. The deed locates a boarded service stair; workers can open it without a check. A quieter entrance runs through a disused coal chute. A DC 13 Investigation check identifies its brittle lower rung; failure costs a noisy landing and 1d6 bludgeoning damage, then reveals the same entrance. At the landing, chisel marks show that someone deliberately removed the society's name. They establish an omission, not who made it or why.

2. The listening desks. Spoken words become faint within arm's reach of a desk; elsewhere they sound normal. This phenomenon does not prevent verbal spell components. Written questions, gestures, or moving a desk work immediately. A brass reading arm moves when paper is laid beneath it. A DC 14 Investigation or Arcana check finds the arm's indexing rhythm; failure jams it until the party spends ten minutes cleaning it. Either outcome produces Catalogue Leaf Nine, handout 1. Its diagram has one center and eight satellites; the ninth identity remains unentered. No answer supplies Site 9's location.

3. The circular table. Eight removable name-slips surround a central depression. Most slips are damaged. The party can reconstruct the count by comparing their edges, without inserting the medallion. Copying the table reveals two separate columns: “recorded” and “sounding.” This establishes that a named site can be dormant. A DC 14 History check also identifies different generations of handwriting; failure leaves the dates uncertain, recoverable later through Selise. Nothing here proves a single builder made every site.

4. The sealed folio. A waxed catalogue packet sits behind a glass panel with a mechanical release. Opening the panel is harmless. Pulling the brass rod behind it begins an optional local test: dust rises and the desks repeat previously spoken words. The inscription warns, “A reading is not a summons.” The party can instead copy the folio through glass or dismantle the panel with tools. The packet contains a coastal bearing diagram useful to Vess and a torn description of pale ground in a living valley - supporting leads to Sites 4 and 5.

Decision and consequences: Selise wants supervised study; a mundane fire-and-water inspection makes clear that leaving fragile pages in place risks their loss. Move the catalogue to the shop, and study becomes easier but the archive loses context until carefully documented. Preserve it in situ, and spend money or favors on protection. Donavan can prepare an Archive-style field packet: copies, find-spots, and a chain of custody. That protects the evidence but raises an honest question about whether he sends copies to the Kemp Archive, given the risk that more scholars attract more attention. Optionally run the warned local test: it restores

several damaged labels but creates an audible two-beat response upstairs, drawing a curious customer who may spread a rumor. This is a disclosed visibility cost, not secret empowerment of Halaster.

Reward and return: the party gains a reliable nine-site index, independent evidence that observation and sounding differ, and a secure research space if they arrange ordinary access with Selise. Let each player choose one harmless marginal curiosity to investigate later. At the Portal, Durnan asks what the quietest place in Waterdeep sounded like.

Site 4 - The Drowned Observatory

Established frame: a wizard's centuries-old flooded coastal observatory; unstable; suggested levels 8-10. Halaster's warning reads “SITE FOUR / UNSUITABLE. / DO NOT RETURN.” The reason remains unknown. Its broken bronze dome lies beneath green-black water.

Objective: retrieve the observation log and determine why the ruin cannot hold a stable measurement. Vess provides true bearings once the party gives her a credible return plan. Her ship cannot solve the underwater portion. Make breathable air, swimming, lights, a tether, and a surface lookout concrete preparations; do not surprise the party with missing equipment after departure.

> *A bronze curve appears below the waves, then disappears beneath the next swell. Through its broken ribs, stars glimmer in daylight. One is reflected twice. Your rope hums against the boat's rail, falls silent, then hums again a heartbeat later.*

1. The tide stair. At the predicted low tide, a fractured service stair reaches an air pocket. The slower route follows the outside dome with tethers; the faster route crosses an exposed gallery. Show the cracked gallery supports before entry. A DC 14 Athletics or Acrobatics check crosses safely; failure costs 2d6 bludgeoning damage and leaves the character on a reachable lower ledge, not swept irretrievably away. Anyone following a secured rope crosses without another check. Both routes reveal the tide-height scale needed below.

2. The keeper's room. A dry cabinet holds the observation log in a ceramic sleeve. Patiently open the swollen cabinet, or succeed on DC 15 thieves' tools to save twenty minutes. Failure damages the cabinet, not the documents. Handout 2 shows that readings become unreliable at a repeatable waterline and preserves Halaster's warning. Comparison with verified dungeon examples confirms the annotation's attribution; until then, mark it as attributed. Its existence does not prove he stood in this room.

3. The drowned lens. A tilted bronze frame sits over a cracked observing floor. An ordinary tide floods two chambers unevenly; the moving water changes the frame's alignment. This explains some unreliable readings, not Halaster's warning or the site's instability. The party can sketch or take a rubbing from the safe perimeter. To reach a trapped salvage diver named Edda Marr, secure the frame with rope or make a DC 15 Athletics check. Failure shifts the load and inflicts 2d6 bludgeoning damage on the helper; Edda remains reachable through a crawlspace that requires abandoning her heavy salvage bag. She knows a safe exit even if distrustful.

4. The counterweight well. An intact tide wheel can hold the frame still for one short observation. Operating it requires two people or one person and a braced tool; no roll is needed after inspecting the linkage. Before use, show that the load will stress a cracked housing. The alternatives are a ten-minute measurement with the party holding the wheel, or leaving a replaceable brace to suppress movement until the next storm. Neither activates or stabilizes the whole network. The measurement records a paired response even after the lens is shuttered: reflected starlight alone cannot explain the Echo.

Decision and consequences: Edda's bag contains valuable mundane salvage but overloads the crawlspace stretcher. Save her first and return for it with preparations, or risk the exposed gallery with both. Afterward choose custody of the log: shared copies let coastal researchers improve warnings; restricted bearings reduce reckless expeditions. Vess supports publication of tide dangers while protecting the precise route. Neither approach stops future trouble entirely.

Reward and return: a brass star plate, the log, and Edda's testimony give three independently usable records. The plate is an accurate mundane observing aid once repaired; it neither finds sites nor opens travel routes. Orren can use its housing design to protect a delicate future instrument. Vess privately offers the name of the friend she lost here if the party treated another diver's life as more valuable than salvage.

Site 5 - Dead God's Scar

Established frame: a pale wound across a living valley; corrupted; suggested levels 10-12. Divine contamination is present. The divine identity and any player-character connection remain undecided.

Objective: protect people suffering shared dreams and obtain evidence distinguishing local exposure from an outside attack. Anja's testimony, Ilvara's survey statements, or public travel records independently identify the valley. The settlement and residents below are new; adopt its name only if no existing campaign geography conflicts.

> *Wheat bends in a warm wind until it reaches the white ground. There, every stalk stands perfectly still. Across the valley, the pale scar climbs a hillside without following the slope. A bell sounds from the village. For an instant, you remember being the person who rang it.*

1. Pale Ford. Six households shelter in a grain hall. Caretaker Teren Moss refuses to leave bedridden residents behind. The dreams share sounds and gestures, but differ in faces; neither a dream nor this site supplies a deity's name. Compare three accounts and the party automatically identifies the same exposure window. A DC 15 Medicine or Insight check additionally separates exhaustion from deliberate exaggeration, saving supplies. Failure means a longer conversation, not false certainty or missing the lead. Handout 3 is a child's ordinary weather-and-sleep diary.

2. The broken field channel. A pale mineral deposit has crossed an irrigation ditch. Water and walking routes now carry dust toward the houses. Diverting the ditch, laying boards, and washing clothes reduce further exposure without “curing” divine corruption. A DC 15 Survival or relevant tool check organizes this before dusk; failure costs a day of work, during which the grain hall remains safe with its doors covered. No PC must become a sacrificial absorber. Cleared ground reveals old retaining stones, evidence that someone previously managed this boundary.

3. The borrowed moment. At the retaining stones, characters experience a brief sensory echo: heat on the left cheek, a hand braced against stone, a bell sounding twice. Ask each player whether to describe their character's emotional response; do not dictate a memory or secret backstory. A DC 16 Arcana or Religion check identifies the experience as repeating consistently when a stone moves. On failure, a second controlled observation confirms repetition while leaving its mechanism unclear. Careful mapping works without any religious expertise. The vision conveys no reliable identity, motive, or final answer.

4. The exposed seam. Beneath a collapsed retaining stone is a palm-wide luminous seam. A discarded survey flag vibrates beside it; moved ten paces away, it stops. The party can document the gradient from outside the bright area. Crossing the marked inner boundary without a rope or paired guide demands a DC 15 Wisdom save; failure causes 3d6 psychic damage and an involuntary step toward the seam, which a guide can stop without rolling. The character remains able to retreat. This is a one-time exposure event, not a domination effect. Temporary stone screens reduce the response locally; explain that a storm could dislodge them.

Decision and consequences: evacuation reduces immediate exposure but costs the harvest and may separate families from care. Staying behind screens preserves homes and work while requiring monitoring and a return plan. Combine approaches by moving vulnerable residents first and supporting a reduced work crew.

Let the party allocate actual helpers and resources. Destroying retaining stones visibly enlarges exposed ground and is therefore an informed risky choice; it is not a hidden puzzle solution.

Reward and return: recovered boundary measurements show that local harm can be reduced without activating the site or proving the Still Hand's entire argument. Teren supplies food, lodging, and an honest future witness. The party carries a practical protection method to other investigations, limited to loose contamination and measured shielding - not a universal divine cure. Back at Lantern House, Anja listens closely to who stayed, who moved, and who accepted responsibility for returning.

Site 6 - The Frozen Door

Established frame: northern glacier; sealed; suggested levels 12-14. An earlier expedition opened the lone black door; only one returned, repeatedly drawing one circle surrounded by eight. Someone other than Halaster sealed it. He was not the first to discover the Nine. The older seal's makers are not automatically the Still Hand.

Objective: recover the maintenance record and assess the seal before deciding whether reopening is justified. Kestrel's partial journal, its auctioned original, and the survivor's testimony independently provide the approach. Resolve provisions beforehand; Vess can arrange the first leg north, not arrival at the glacier.

> *Snow has erased the mountain's ordinary edges. One rectangle remains: a black doorway standing in blue ice. Frost stops a finger's width from its surface. Beside it, a row of old camp rings lies empty. Every one faces away from the door.*

1. The expedition shelf. The surviving journal identifies a sheltered traverse. Without it, cairns and a distant exposed camp establish the route. A DC 16 Survival check finds the efficient approach; failure costs half a day's provisions and reaches the same shelter. Do not start an unrecoverable resource spiral. Here the party finds a marked rope, spare mittens, and a note warning that smoke flowing toward the door signals unsafe wind. The expedition did not disappear merely because someone failed a check.

2. The outward camp. Researcher Ossa Fen has spent three days repairing a sled and can leave if helped. They want a readable maintenance plaque, not treasure inside. Melt its ice layer slowly, or use a DC 16 tool check to remove it quickly. Failure cracks a redundant corner but leaves every instruction legible. Handout 4 records deliberate sealing and exterior inspection. Its handwriting predates known Still Hand documents but establishes no exact age without further study.

3. The inspection stones. Three exposed markers flank the black doorway. They are exterior indicators, not keys that force it open. A thread suspended between two markers shows which cracked marker is vibrating. Repeating the test confirms that damage to one anchor has weakened local damping. A DC 17 Arcana or mason's-tools check identifies the most stable repair; failure still locates the crack but requires a second work period to test the fix. During a careless rushed attempt, falling ice deals 3d6 bludgeoning damage, avoided by using the rope shelter Ossa has already indicated. The maintenance record remains accessible outside.

4. The face of the door. The party can examine hinges, old patching, and tool marks without opening anything. They reveal successive maintenance, not an untouched primordial barrier. Readings outside suggest pressure rises during paired pulses; the source beyond remains unknown. The party can reinforce the external marker, leave a passive witness strip for a future visit, or propose a limited opening. A proposed opening is a separate expedition: require a retreat route, observations, and a way to close the actual seal before resolving it. No medallion touch automatically unlocks this adventure.

Decision and consequences: the repair uses a ceramic insert that Ossa hoped to study. Install it and preserve the present barrier; recover its full design first through rubbings and measurements. Take it intact instead, and leave the already weakened seal under a disclosed maintenance deadline after the next major thaw. Breaking the seal immediately is possible through a method supported by actual play, but the party has enough evidence to understand that it is an irreversible experiment with an unknown interior. Do not punish refusal with a mandatory opening.

Reward and return: the maintenance record supplies a tested model for reversible local isolation and a physical distinction between ancient workmanship and modern acquisition efforts. Donavan can compare the seal's notation to the Kemp Archive's traditions without declaring a link that evidence does not support. The party also earns Ossa's future field assistance and Kestrel's respect if they credit the incomplete journal fairly. Anja welcomes evidence that preservation and sealing can coexist; her faction's harder members may dispute its sufficiency without making her argument dishonest.

Site 7 - The Walking Tower

Established frame: mobile; suggested levels 14-16. Its asymmetrical stepped crown remains recognizable across appearances. It contains a Looking Glass fragment. Halaster is trying to catch it; the party can arrive first. It is not a universal transport service.

Objective: predict an appearance, board safely, and recover the fragment with enough context to interpret it later. Selise's sketches, Pell's dated routes, and Vess's fisher witness independently identify the same tower. The party travels normally to its expected area; no Echo connection provides transit.

> *Beyond the ridge stands a tower that was absent a moment ago. Its highest steps lean toward the wrong side of the sky. Grass lies flattened in a perfect ring around its foot. A window opens, and a strip of blue cloth flutters out - someone has been waiting for the ground to return.*

1. The arrival ring. Comparing any two dated observations establishes a probable appearance window. A DC 17 Investigation or Survival check narrows it to one watch; failure means a cold night of waiting with a clear sightline. Before the tower changes position again, loose pebbles begin climbing its outer wall and the entry bell vibrates. These warnings give at least ten minutes to exit. This adventure takes place during a long enough stationary interval; do not move the tower merely to invalidate sensible preparation.

2. The lower landing. An itinerant conservator named Linn Aster entered to rescue drawings and stayed too long. Linn wants help moving two document chests down ordinary stairs. A narrow stair crack can be crossed with a plank or DC 15 Acrobatics; failure leaves someone hanging within reach and spills one chest. The documents can be gathered, costing twenty minutes. Linn can identify a Looking Glass inventory number but does not know why the larger project was abandoned. Their confident personal theory must be explicitly marked as a guess in dialogue.

3. The tilted study. Furniture is chained to the walls; its placement shows the room has tilted before. A brass mounting collar holds a curved fragment wrapped in old cloth. Handout 5 is the attached packing slip, establishing its provenance without explaining the full machine. Three disconnected measuring needles respond together when a tuning fork is struck beside the fragment. Document this behavior locally. It does not itself prove amplification; reserve that conclusion for the established deep-dungeon evidence. A DC 17 Arcana check distinguishes the fragment's response from room vibration; failure means repeating the test after padding the table.

4. The counterweight room. The collar currently acts as a mundane counterweight in a later repair. An engraved mass mark and spare stone blocks make the consequence visible: simply pulling it free would tip the study floor. Replace its mass, brace the floor, or leave the fragment and take precise rubbings. A DC 16 Athletics or tool check moves a substitute quickly; failure tips loose furnishings and causes 3d6 bludgeoning damage to an unbraced helper. A slow pulley method takes thirty minutes and requires no roll. Successful extraction does not control the tower's movements or create a travel command.

Decision and consequences: the next movement warning arrives after the party has time for one final careful operation: finish hauling Linn's heaviest chest or rescue an additional set of fragile diagrams. They may organize extra help in advance and save both. Prioritize the chest and preserve ordinary families' property records; choose diagrams and preserve technical context. This is a preparation problem, not an unavoidable

sacrifice. Linn is upset by lost records but can be persuaded through honest explanation, never a single roll that erases the loss.

Reward and return: the fragment, its measured copy, or a documented decision to leave it all count as success. Selise gains provenance; Orren can examine construction techniques. Record custody and any later deliberate experiment separately. At home, Kestrel asks whether getting somewhere no one else has been matters more than bringing back something others can use.

Site 8 - The Broken Star

Established frame: planar investigation; extremely unstable; suggested levels 16-18. Fractured light, strange gravity and distance, overlapping rooms, and an impossible view of Waterdeep suggest the Nine have implications beyond one plane. Clues establish the need for investigation, not the means of travel.

Objective: obtain comparable observations from a safe approach and determine how a proposed intervention changes local instability. Before starting, establish a legitimate outward journey and return method using the party's actual capabilities or a negotiated ally. Honor the chosen travel method's limits and costs. This adventure supplies no new universal portal or automatic medallion destination.

> *A broken star hangs below your feet and above the ridge ahead. Its pieces illuminate one another with delayed light. Along the shore of empty space, stones cast shadows toward three different horizons. Your companion raises a hand. Their shadow lowers its own a moment later.*

1. The arrival shelf. A stable shelf contains weathered tether points and handout 6, an earlier survey's brass index. Its author's fate remains unknown. Mark the return point before approaching the star. A DC 17 Survival or Arcana check identifies the indexed path; failure costs an hour of mapping and reveals the same route. No failed check scatters the party across planes. A visible crack grows whenever two fragments align, signaling the approach hazard.

2. The contrary path. Two routes reach the observation ridge: a narrow anchored traverse or a broad reflective slope. The traverse requires rope and patient movement, with no check after secure preparation. The slope saves time but imposes a DC 17 Dexterity save at one announced shift; failure causes 4d6 force damage and slides the traveler into a shallow rock basin where companions can lower a rope. The basin is a recovery position, not a hidden bottomless drop. Both routes expose a repeated change in shadow direction just before alignment.

3. The broken instrument. Two observatory rooms overlap; their doors show the same unreachable Waterdeep rooftops. These views offer no traversable route. An instrument compares three horizons using shutters. One shutter is jammed with star-glass: carefully clear it with tools or succeed on DC 18 Sleight of Hand to save time. Failure breaks a sample, requiring a mundane wedge. One slit gives consistent measurements; opening all three gives incompatible readings. Record both. This demonstrates a measurement problem without resolving the site's cosmology or Looking Glass's abandonment.

4. The alignment interval. The next visible alignment occurs after sufficient time to plan. Use three observations to predict it, or simply wait at the protected ridge and watch. A detachable shutter can reduce exposure at the ridge for the interval, making a second reading safer. Leave it in place to protect future visitors, retrieve it for research, or build a mundane replacement before departing. If characters choose to stand in the unshielded marked area, a DC 18 Constitution save halves 4d6 radiant damage from one pulse. Observation remains possible from cover; enduring damage yields no exclusive revelation.

Decision and consequences: a coherent star-glass sample could support a bounded later experiment, but extracting it loosens the instrument's oldest tether. This is visible under load. Stabilize with expedition gear, take only inert chips, or leave it and bring measurements. Record the instrument's resulting condition for a possible return. Deliberate synchronization is a separate, consented choice with a stated hypothesis and stopping rule; the adventure never treats carrying a sample as automatic activation.

Reward and return: the party brings back a repeatable warning sign, safer observation procedure, and evidence of how little one measurement can establish. Star-glass is an unusual research material, not an assigned magic-item bonus. Donavan can write Dianna a precisely limited account: observations, confidence levels, and no claims the party cannot reproduce. Her mathematical reply can later identify a pattern in their data without remotely solving the problem. Orren can incorporate the documented optical behavior into a later prototype chosen by the PCs. On Starcup Roof, Selise asks each character which uncertainty most changes their preferred next step. Preserve those answers for the late campaign; do not announce a predetermined solution or locate the Hollow Mountain here.

Clues, handouts, and campaign records

Prepared future material: these handouts and their recovery scenes are planned, not proof that players found them. Publish each only after the actual discovery, and record who saw it in Campaign continuity.

All six texts are **NEW campaign development**. The numbered labels help the DM match them to Sites 3-8; give players only the individual text below the divider. These handouts supplement investigation and can be copied, translated, or read aloud without a check. They never require possession of Echo's Whisper.

Handout 1 - Catalogue Leaf Nine

Recovered from the Silent Library's reading arm.

The central entry is counted among the Nine.

Eight leaves surround it. Do not add the center a second time.

Under **RECORDED**, enter the identity.

Under **SOUNDING**, enter the condition observed and the date.

A sleeping place does not cease to exist. A named place has not necessarily answered.

The last leaf remains blank. A blank is not an invitation to invent an answer.

Handout 2 - A Keeper's Tide Record

Recovered in a ceramic document sleeve at the Drowned Observatory.

Third watch. Water below the lower stair. West frame steady.

Fourth watch. Water at the scored line. Two readings from one lamp. The frame has shifted again.

Fifth watch. Shutter closed. The paired response continues.

We must record water and light separately. Otherwise the next keeper will blame the sky for a fault beneath their feet.

Lower margin, in another hand:

SITE FOUR

UNSUITABLE.

DO NOT RETURN.

Handout 3 - Seven Nights in the Valley

A page copied from a child's notebook at Pale Ford.

First night: rain. No bell in my sleep.

Second night: washed the porch. No bell.

Third night: dry wind from the white field. Bell twice. Mother heard it too.

Fourth night: slept in the grain hall. Dreamed about our goat instead.

Fifth night: took Father's coat inside. Bell again. His coat was white at the cuffs.

Sixth night: Teren washed everything. No bell.

Seventh night: somebody said the bell knows our names.

It has never said mine.

Handout 4 - Exterior Maintenance Plaque

Copied from an ice-covered plaque beside the Frozen Door.

The closure is deliberate.

Inspection is to be made from this side.

Check the three markers before disturbing the face. Compare the still thread against the moving thread. Replace the cracked seat before the thaw.

Do not mistake the absence of a sound for the absence of a load.

If the work cannot be completed, leave a dated warning at the outer shelter.

Those who follow deserve more than our confidence.

Handout 5 - Looking Glass Packing Slip

Tied around the curved fragment in the Walking Tower.

LOOKING GLASS - RETURNED FITTING

One curved piece. One brass collar. Packing cloth to remain between stone and metal.

Copy the fitting number before removing the wrapping. Record every change of custody.

This parcel does not include the assembly instructions.

Do not infer the use of the whole from the behavior of this piece.

Later pencil note:

The collar will hold the floor until we have a proper weight. Mark its mass before anyone borrows it again.

Handout 6 - The Three-Horizon Index

Etched on a brass strip at the Broken Star's arrival shelf.

Name the ledge before naming a direction.

One slit. One horizon. One observation.

Close the first before opening the second. If all three agree too neatly, check the shutters.

The shadows turn before the pieces align. Return to cover when the third shadow crosses the first.

Leave a tether for the journey back.

If you find our instrument, preserve the measurements you can repeat. Cross out the conclusions you cannot.

Running the table

Campaign continuity at the table

Use Story > Campaign continuity & quests. Add an event with its session, source, status, and evidence basis. Write the separate player-safe wording, select who knows it, and link affected quests, map locations, promises, debts, rescues, escapes, or items. Review the shared preview before approving. Only facts and completed events change quest progress or tracked custody; rumors remain leads. Draft the next recap from approved events and review it before publishing.

For the current stopping point, see Session-02-03-Actual-Recap.md. Keep the Redbrand hideout prepared, not completed. Use continuity Undo/Redo to reverse record edits; this is separate from combat Undo.

A simple session loop

1. Open with **one welcome**: food, a letter, a repaired item, a regular table, or a person remembering a promise.
2. State **one change**: an NPC's decision, new evidence, a cost, or an affected community.
3. Offer **up to two leads**. A lead should state destination, what is known, and what preparation would help.
4. End by recording a promise, a site condition, and what the party wants to do next.

Fail forward

Use checks to change price, time, safety, precision, or attention - never whether the central clue exists. Show hazards before a roll. On a failure, give the lead and add one concrete consequence such as lost time, minor damage, a noisy approach, depleted supplies, or a rumor spreading. A sensible tool, spell, or physical plan should substitute for a roll.

Site record

Copy this row for each site.

1-9

Starting condition: active, dormant, unstable, etc.

Current condition: unexamined / observed / deliberately tuned / isolated / severed

People affected:

Evidence / custody:

Next consequence:

Evidence labels

Keep table talk clean by labeling discoveries:

- **Observed:** directly measured or witnessed.
- **Inferred:** a plausible conclusion from facts.
- **Claimed:** someone says it; their motive or evidence may be incomplete.
- **Open:** deliberately unanswered.

This makes the mystery fair. It also lets factions disagree without one of them being secretly foolish.

Difficulty and attendance adjustments

The current party has five PCs: Trista, Pebble, Donavan Kemp, Ringgo Paul, and Aldric Vane. Treat satellite DCs and hazards as starting suggestions for the level and situation, not a numerical guarantee. Reassess after major level changes or when someone is absent. Do not solve low numbers with surprise extra combat. Instead, lower a DC by 2, add a safe method that takes time, give an allied NPC a logistical role, reduce damage, or turn a combat into a choice to escape, bargain, or secure a route. Use published creature statistics whenever a creature battle matters.

NPC relationship clock

For each recurring NPC, mark **distant, known, trusted, strained, or opposed**. Change it only after an observable scene. Trust gives help that matches the NPC's role, not free solutions: Durnan gives a room and honesty; Selise gives research; Vess gives travel planning; Anja gives care and hard questions. Keep the city from becoming a quest-vending machine.

The visual language

Warm human scenes use rain-dark slate, worn brass, cream paper, and amber windows. Echo scenes use restrained violet-gray light and doubled shadows. The selected campaign art direction is watercolor and gouache with ink edges and parchment texture. The images are campaign concept art rather than official portraits, maps, or binding canon.